FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

For a state that does not always make it to the mainstream of news, it is tragic that it took near-civil war conditions for Manipur to register on the national consciousness. The scenes playing out now in the Imphal valley and the high ranges surrounding it are shocking in a modern India. Two warring ethnic groups, the Meiteis and the Kukis, have barricaded themselves against each other after a near-complete population transfer. No Meitei is left in the hills, no Kuki in the valley. This includes those in civil administration, health services, education, banking and policing. The police, in fact, is split down the middle on partisan lines. It has either stayed a mute spectator or perhaps even collaborated in anarchy, having commonly alleged to have facilitated lynching and rape and the loot of armoury. In fact, the armouries were not exactly looted but, in an unprecedented manner, the arms were handed out to mobs and civilian vigilantes on either side. That encapsulated Manipur's descent into chaos. The numbers are scary: 179 killed, 60,000 displaced, nearly 4,000 cases of arson, and well over 10,000 FIRs. Confronted with this spiral, the Indian State, too, is in retreat. The only role for national security forces at present is to stave off further hostilities, mostly by patrolling the no man's land between the two sides, marked off by bunkers manned by armed civilians.

This scenario is all the more tragic because of what preceded it. All the causative elements of conflict were present when the Bharatiya Janata Party came to power for the first time in the state in 2017, but these had been lulled into a zone of subdued latency. In fact, in March 2022, the BJP secured a second term with a majority on its own, winning 32 of Manipur's 60 seats, with Biren Singh re-elected chief minister. That spoke of a disarming level of normalcy. The catastrophic fall we have seen in the summer of 2023 shows that was a delusion. Manipur is now a man-made catastrophe. Pardon the gender bias, for women have been part of it too. Not just as victims—like the Kuki women in the viral video, who had to bear the burden of bringing Manipur to national attention on their bodies—but also as agents and participants in the breakdown of law and morality. Women's groups that once stood proudly for the honour and selfhood of Manipur now not only disrupt food truck movement and ambush security forces to have militants released but have even faced allegations of being enablers of crimes against women. That it is even being thought and said reveals the depth of the ethnic chasm.



GROUND ZERO Deputy Chief Photographer Chandradeep Kumar and Executive Editor Kaushik Deka in Singda village

What brought this beautiful state to this unholy mess? The root cause is old-style 'blood and soil' politics. The Meiteis, mostly Hindu, dominate the state's population, polity and culture but have of late exhibited majoritarian tendencies. One tangible factor is that Meiteis, who constitute 53 per cent of the population, live on 11 per cent of the land, even if it's all in the fertile Imphal valley. The Kukis and Nagas, who constitute 16 and 24 per cent respectively and are mostly Christian, inhabit the state's forested high ranges. The Meiteis want a piece of those hills, mainly those occupied by the Kukis, but can't get it. The tribal status of Kukis protects their ownership. Part of a mountainous continuum straddling Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and contiguous areas of Myanmar, this swathe was partitioned into its modern boundaries only in the 20th century; Manipur got statehood only in 1972. The Kuki-Chin-Zo ethnic continuum still spills over those boundaries, and that's feeding a new insider/outsider narrative of xenophobia in Meiteis. They routinely raise the "illegal immigrant" red flag these days, a lightning-rod slogan of chauvinist politics familiar from other contexts.

A less abstract part of this story is opium. All hands in Manipur are in the till when it comes to drug money, and UN reports speak of a surge in opium cultivation next door in Myanmar after the 2021 coup, with suggestions of an inevitable spike in inflow into Manipur. Kuki refugees too are fleeing the civil war on the other side. The influx came to carry a more loaded meaning in the context of the ongoing war on drugs, where the Biren Singh government claimed poppy cultivation in the Kuki hills to have grown three-fold between 2017 and 2022, from 1,853 acres to 6,743 acres. Biren, who initiated the anti-poppy drive in the hills, is commonly seen to be acting for Meitei interests. So the drive was perceived to be part of a larger Meitei incursion into the hills, aided by the labelling of Kukis as "illegal citizens" engaged in illicit narcotics business. A high court order on granting tribal status to Meiteis—rescinded for now—added to that impression. Biren's actions, therefore, tied up the diverse threads of majoritarian assertion, ethnic rivalry, land, religion and xenophobia into an incendiary cocktail. After it caught fire, his inaction did the rest.

This week's cover story describes this eruption of darkness in the India story and the human folly behind it. Executive Editor Kaushik Deka brings his intimate understanding of the Northeast to look at why things went so terribly wrong, and who is to blame—an analysis held together by an exhaustive ground report for which he and Deputy Chief Photographer Chandradeep Kumar travelled across Manipur. It is our common concern now to look at possible solutions. The Centre has a dilemma on its hands. The Opposition has mounted a sustained attack on the Modi government for largely remaining a spectator to the strife engulfing Manipur. Prime Minister Modi's nearly three-month-long silence, broken only to condemn the horrible incident whose video went viral, has also come in for flak. The embarrassment of a state unravelling so spectacularly under BJP rule should be the lesser of its concerns. It should not even be thinking of future electoral gains from this mess. Undoubtedly, the situation is complicated. Even the Meiteis are angry with the Centre for not being harsh enough on the Kukis. The question is only what must be done to bring normalcy to the state. We review various options. Should it sack Biren Singh and impose President's rule? The pros seem obvious enough: he has presided over a breakdown of the state. The con is that the chief minister is a hero for the Meiteis and also has Naga support, and it may all go from bad to worse. But if the Meiteis are talking about their old separatist agenda and the Kukis about a separate state, and the heat is spreading to Mizoram, it's surely time for urgent action. The Centre has finally initiated talks with both sides, a process the PM is personally monitoring. Hopefully, it will bring an end to the bloodletting—a chapter that has been a blot on a rising nation.

(Aroon Purie)